Vicarious Social Comparison: Parents' Social Media Use and Their Expectations for Adolescent and Young Adult Children

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In recent years, concern about the potential influence of social media on adolescents and young adults has become commonplace among parents, educators, and legislators. A lot of the concern centers around body image, but it extends to domains like self-esteem and overall well-being as well. Parents, policymakers, educators, and even young people themselves have begun to talk about whether exposure to a non-stop stream of images of attractive people, often enhanced by filters and careful lighting, might not be bad for teens. This concern is, if not uniformly, supported by research. Overall, social media use is associated with more body image disturbance (Saiphoo & Vahedi, 2019), and many studies find small, negative effects of social media on self-esteem (for a review see Cingel et al., 2022)

An important mechanism for these harmful effects of social media is social comparison. Festinger (1954) famously noted that, absent other information, humans are prone to judge themselves by comparison with others. Everyone engages in social comparison from time to time. We judge how interesting our weekend was by comparing it to what our friends did with their weekend. If we had a quiet weekend in and had a really good takeout pizza, even if that's what we wanted to do at the time, we might feel bad on Monday when we find out a coworker went to a concert or spent a day whitewater rafting. We judge how successful we are by comparing ourselves to our neighbors, classmates, or friends; the idea of "Keeping up with the Joneses" is all about making purchases in order to not lose ground in a constant state of social comparison.

Importantly, it is likely that we don't only engage in social comparison for ourselves, but for others who are close to us as well. For example, Dr. Taylor, one of the authors of this chapter,

is a parent. When one of his sons was about 18 months old, they lived in a neighborhood with lots of other small children. One neighbor child was almost exactly the same age, but he was already speaking in complete (if generally inane) sentences. Up to that point, Dr. Taylor had thought his son was doing great. The pediatrician said he was hitting all the relevant developmental milestones, and he was by all indicators an active, engaged, curious child. But after seeing the neighbor kid talk circles around *his* kid, Dr. Taylor started to wonder if his son was doing as well as he should be. He was engaging in social comparison not to evaluate himself, but to evaluate his son. And as a consequence, his expectations for his son were different than they might have been otherwise.

Today, for many parents, social media sites have taken on the character of that neighborhood filled with precocious youngsters against which parents are prone to compare their own children. Facebook feeds are filled with human-interest news articles about high-achieving children ("Teen Accepted to All Eight Ivy League Schools," "14-year-old Invents Soap to Fight Skin Cancer," etc.). Parents see videos of children's peak athletic and artistic achievements ("Little League Pitchers Hurl 80 MPH Fastballs," "Nine-year-old Violin Prodigy Wins International Competition," etc.). Even the personal posts, pictures, and videos from their actual interpersonal networks are often focused on their peers' children at their very best—people post about their child being named valedictorian, their child's all-state choir concert, their child looking fabulous for the homecoming dance.

The algorithmification of social media spaces has meant that content in those spaces is increasingly highly specific to the characteristics and social roles of audiences. For parents, this means seeing content designed for parents. And parents, overwhelmingly, are on social media (Duggan et al., 2015). This is hardly surprising; most people in the world are on social media

(Nyst, 2023). What is interesting, though, is how parents use social media. Most are on social media at least daily, more often than non-parents, and most parents on social media report getting useful information about parenting specifically through social media channels (Duggan et al., 2015). Again, this is understandable; social media sites are expert at exposing users to content that they will find engaging, and such engagement is as likely to be tied to social roles (like being a parent) as it is to anything else.

And we don't have to assume that parents are prone to engage in social comparison when they go online. Evidence has shown that parents do, in fact, engage in social comparison with social media targets regarding their parenting, with consequences for their expectations for and evaluations of themselves as parents. Exposure to social media messages sharing idealized representations of motherhood, for example, has been shown to cause envy and anxiety among new mothers (Kirkpatrick & Lee, 2022).

Although we engage in social comparison to understand and evaluate ourselves, we can also engage in similar processes to understand and evaluate other people. When we engage in such comparisons for strangers or distant others, it is probably best understood as a sort of applied learning—we learn some set of general expectations about how people can or should behave, then we apply that standard when judging others. For example, Taylor and Setters (2011) found that watching clips from action movies featuring violent, stereotypically attractive, female protagonists caused viewers to shift their expectations for women's behavior in general.

When we engage in comparisons to understand or evaluate people who are close to us, however, the process seems to be more like a sort of vicarious social comparison. For example, Thai and Lockwood (2015) observed that people who compare their romantic partner to some other individual respond in much the same way that they respond when comparing themselves to

others. Other research has found that when young adults compared a parent to another person, it affected their views of and feelings toward that parent; the same thing happens when parents make comparisons about their children (Thai et al., 2019). When we compare people who are close to us to others, it changes how we think about them, just like when we compare ourselves to others, it changes how we think about ourselves. Thai and Lockwood (2015) argue that this occurs because we consider those close to us to be a sort of extension of ourselves—my parents or children are included in my self-concept, they are part of me.

Research has shown that parents do, in fact, engage in social comparisons with regard to their children. They do so to evaluate their children in a wide range of domains, including physical, social, and cognitive, from a young age (Zhang & Yan, 2024). These comparisons have the capacity to influence the children of such parents. Parents' participation in social comparison regarding their children has been shown to impact child self-esteem, for example (Liu et al., 2025). It is easy to see how such influence could come about—social comparison leads parents to change how they evaluate their children, those evaluations then influence how the parents interact with those same children, and the children respond to the way their parents treat them.

Given that parents engage in vicarious social comparisons for their children, we wondered whether such comparisons would occur more often as a result of parental social media use. We reasoned that, given the proliferation of depictions of high-achieving children on parents' social media feeds, that parents who spent more time on social media may start to compare their own children with those high-achievers. The result would likely be elevated expectations for their own children—expecting them to live up to (or at least come closer to living up to) the children from the idealized depictions they see online.

Parental expectations for their children can have complex consequences. On the one hand, relatively high expectations can be experienced as a sort of parental vote of confidence, strengthening children's sense of worth and their own potential. For example, a study of children with disabilities in Ireland found that when parents had relatively higher expectations for their children when those children were young, the children subsequently tended to do better in school and have better self-concept during early adolescence (McCoy et al., 2016). Of course, this may be due to parents having relatively higher expectations for children who will eventually do well in school. Regardless, particularly high expectations may also set children up for failure; worry about not meeting parental expectations can result in negative outcomes. For example, one cross-cultural study found that college students' life satisfaction and self-esteem depended, in part, on whether they believed that they had met their parents' expectations (Oishi & Sullivan, 2005).

The nature of parental expectations, wherever they come from, on children's outcomes likely depends, at least in part, on how parents communicate—and enforce—the expectations that they hold for their children. Researchers often describe styles of parenting using four categories: neglectful or uninvolved, permissive or indulgent, authoritative, and authoritarian parenting (Maccoby & Martin, 1983). The style that might most problematically be associated with high parental expectations is authoritarian parenting. Authoritarian parenting is characterized by a high degree of parental control, a focus on obedience to parental authority, and a lack of responsiveness to children's ideas and input (Baumrind, 1991). One can imagine a parent with an authoritarian parenting style and very high expectations for their children communicating their disappointment when their child fails to meet those expectations. For that matter, even the idea that a parent's expectations for a child should be preeminent, that a parent

has a right to impose their expectations on the child, is more consistent with an authoritarian approach to parenting than with other parenting styles.

With this in mind, we suspected that parental influence and social media might depend, in part, on the degree to which parents adopted an authoritarian parenting style.

It is important to remember, though, that not all parents are equally likely to engage in the kinds of vicarious social comparison that can lead to shifting expectations for children (and its knock-on consequences). Social comparison orientation (SCO) is the term used to describe how much people tend to engage in social comparison as a general rule, whether in terms of appearance, success, or opinions (Gibbons & Buunk, 1999). Although social comparison is a widespread phenomenon, some people engage in such comparisons more often than others. People who are more prone to engage in social comparison, or in other words, those high in SCO, tend to engage in such comparisons more often or to give more importance to them. For example, Lee (2014) found in a large survey that people who scored higher on a measure of SCO also engaged in more social comparison on social media sites and, perhaps as a consequence, tended to be more self-conscious. Vogel and colleagues (2015) found that individuals higher in SCO were more heavily influenced by social media comparisons in areas as diverse as self-esteem and emotional balance. Nor are the consequences of SCO limited to media models; higher SCO has also been linked to comparisons in educational settings, resulting in higher self-expectations (Sheffler & Cheung, 2023).

High parental expectations for their children may not only influence children and their relationships with their parents—high expectations may well affect parents directly, specifically by increasing the anxiety parents experience. If we understand anxiety to be an emotional state

that looks to the future with apprehension, worry, and a lack of control (see Barlow, 2000), we can readily imagine how such a link might come to be. High expectations are not necessarily accompanied by confidence that one's child can meet those expectations—in fact, the higher the expectations, the greater the likelihood that a child will not. For a young child, a parent might expect that their own behavior—the guidance, instruction, and opportunities they provide for their child—may help bring those expectations to fruition. For the parent of an adolescent or young adult, the die has pretty much been cast. On the other hand, it is easy to imagine that greater anxiety may lead to more frequent or more intense social media use; uncertainty and trepidation may motivate time on social media to seek confirmation that one's child is achieving at a normal level, that one is parenting appropriately, and so on. Past research has identified links between the experience of anxiety and social media use among emerging adults (Vannucci et al., 2017; Xie & Karan, 2019); we investigated whether such links occur among parents of adolescents and emerging adults.

Methods

Overall Design

We took a dual-method approach to addressing our questions, combining an experiment and a survey. For the experimental element, we manipulated social media posts about high school seniors; half of our participants saw posts of three super-successful high school seniors (e.g., inventor and entrepreneur, international science fair winner, etc.), while the other half of participants saw posts of three ordinary seniors (e.g., part-time retail worker, got a 'B' in chemistry, etc.). The experiment, frankly, did not work; there was no effect of experimental condition. Each post was only viewed for 30 seconds, and in the context of regular social media

use (which, again, averages about an hour a day for most adults), it is likely that these brief messages just made no difference.

We also, however, collected survey measures at the same time. By controlling for experimental condition in all analyses (see Ward, 2002), we were able to identify relationships among social media use, social comparison orientation, and expectations parents had for their children. The study integrated the survey and experimental elements. Parents who were recruited to participate were given a link to a survey research site (Qualtrics). The first page was a consent form, and participants who gave consent were directed to the survey. In the survey, they completed measures of social media use, social comparison orientation, and expectations of their children. They also looked at a series of faux social media posts about teens (the experimental portion).

Sample

A total of 295 parents of at least one child between the ages of 15 and 25 completed the survey. Participants were recruited through introductory classes at a large, public university—students were offered a small amount of extra credit for recruiting one parent participant. Although many reported recruiting one of their own parents, others recruited a sibling, former teacher, coworker, or friend. The racial and ethnic make-up of the sample was reflective of the university student body that recruited it; 45% of participants identified as Asian or Asian-American, 28% as White or European-American, 14% as Hispanic or Latino, 7% as South Asian or Indian, and smaller percentages as Black or African-American, Native American, Pacific Islander, or other. Most participants self-identified as female (73%), with most of the rest identifying as male (26%); one participant demurred to identify their sex.

Measures

Social media use was measured with a single item. Participants were asked to indicate how many hours they spent on a number of different activities, one of which was “all social media.” They responded with a slider tool that allowed only whole numbers from 0 to 24. Responses ranged from zero (n = 24, or 8.1%) to 10 (n = 1, 0.3%) (M = 2.79, SD = 2.04). Although single-item measures have inherent limitations, they are increasingly found to be useful and valid (see Allen et al., 2022; Matthews et al., 2022).

Social comparison tendencies were measured using the Iowa-Netherlands Comparison Orientation Measure (INCOM) developed by Gibbons and Buunk (1999). This scale included 11 items scored on a 5-point Likert scale, with example items such as “I always pay a lot of attention to how I do things compared with how others do things.”

To evaluate parental expectations that parents held for children, we used the Parental Expectancy Scale by Eisen et al. (2004). This scale contains 20 reflecting high expectations parents might hold for their children in a range of domains. The specific types of expectations are academic pursuits (4 items, e.g., “I expect my child to enter a top university,”), extracurricular activities (4 items, e.g., “I expect my child will distinguish him/herself with top performances in his/her extra-curricular activities,”) home life (4 items, e.g., “I expect my child to take initiative in helping out in the home”), social life (4 items, e.g., “I expect my child to increase the quality or quantity of his/her friendships”), and general expectations (4 items, e.g., “I expect my child to achieve his/her full potential in life”). Reliability for these sub-scales was acceptable (alphas ranged from .65 to .77).

Parenting style was operationalized as authoritarian parenting, measured using the Authoritarian Parenting Style scale (Robinson et al., 1995). This 13-item scale asks parents to indicate the frequency with which they engage in a range of strict, often punitive parenting

practices (e.g., “I use threats as a form of punishment with little or no justification,” “I openly criticize my child when his/her behavior does not meet my expectations”). Responses were made on a 6-point scale (1 = never, 6 = always), and were averaged to form a single measure of authoritarian parenting (alpha = .92, *M* = 2.09, *SD* = .76).

The degree to which participants were anxious was measured using elements drawn from the State Trait Anxiety Inventory (STAI) (Spielberger, 1983). The STAI is a 20-item questionnaire that asks respondents to indicate how much a number of emotions or statements reflect their “present feelings”; 9 of those statements reflect calm and tranquility (e.g., “I feel calm,” “I feel secure”), and 11 reflect anxious feelings (e.g., “I feel nervous,” “I am worried”). We used the 11 anxiety-related items (alpha = .91, *M* = 1.72, *SD* = .60).

Results

First, it was apparent that the parents in our sample did, indeed, have high expectations for their children. For each of the measures of parental expectations, mean scores were in the range of “true more often than not” (coded as a 3) or “usually true” (coded as a 4). This applied to academic expectations (*M* = 3.91, *SD* = .98), extracurricular expectations (*M* = 3.79, *SD* = 1.05), social expectations (*M* = 3.41, *SD* = 1.00), for expectations in the home (*M* = 4.39, *SD* = .97), and for general expectations (*M* = 4.23, *SD* = .88).

Our initial analyses were intended to examine whether the tendency to have such high expectations for their children was associated with particular patterns of social media use or engagement. We began by conducting a multivariate regression, with the five types of expectations as dependent variables and social comparison orientation and social media use as independent variables. We also included participant sex and household income as controls. A

multivariate effect was observed for social comparison orientation, F (5, 248) = 5.59, $p < .001$, and for social media use, F (5, 248) = 3.67, $p = .003$). Follow-up univariate regression analyses indicated that social comparison orientation was positively associated with all five types of parental expectations. Social media use was only significantly associated with academic expectations ($B = .067$, $SE = .032$, $p = .039$) and social expectations ($B = .10$, $SE = .031$, $p = .002$).

To explore whether these effects of social media were moderated by SCO, we conducted an additional regression analysis for academic and social expectations in which the interaction between social media use and SCO was added as a predictor. Interestingly, when the interaction between SCO and social media use was added, it did not add significantly to the equation's explanatory power for academic expectations. However, the interaction was a significant and positive predictor of social expectations ($B = .102$, $SE = .043$, $p = .018$)—the higher a parent's SCO, the stronger the relationship between social media use and high social expectations for their child.

We next turned our attention to the possibility of relationships among social media use, SCO, and authoritarian parenting. A regression analysis identified a significant, positive relationship between authoritarian parenting and social media use ($B = .055$, $SE = .024$, $p = .024$) but not SCO ($B = .11$, $SE = .099$, *n.s.*). The more time parents spent on social media, the more likely they were to engage in authoritarian parenting practices. There was no significant interaction between SCO and social media use.

Finally, we examined the relationships among social media use, SCO, and anxiety. We found a significant, positive relationship between social media use and the experience of anxiety ($B = .046$, $SE = .020$, $p = .020$), though none for SCO or for their interaction. Spending more

time on social media was significantly associated with experiencing more anxiety among our present sample.

Discussion

In a sample of almost 300 parents of teen-aged or young-adult children, we observed relationships between time spent on social media by parents and elevated expectations for their children, a tendency to engage in more authoritarian parenting, and greater anxiety. Because these observations were made based on the cross-sectional measures, we cannot conclude that social media use is, in each case, the *cause* in these relationships. At the same time, we must consider these findings in the context of the growing body of research that identifies the potential harm of frequent social media use.

One of the most robust findings was the positive association between SCO and all five types of parental expectations. Parents who are inclined to monitor how they and their families compare to others were especially likely to endorse elevated standards for their children's performance and development. This pattern aligns with the notion of vicarious social comparison; parents seem to use others' achievements as benchmarks for evaluation of their children's success. In an age where "good parenting" is often defined implicitly and (or even explicitly) by children's educational and professional outcomes, high-SCO parents may be especially vulnerable to internalizing competitive norms about achievement, sociability, and overall life success.

Social media use showed a more selective pattern of associations, associated with academic and social expectations but not expectations in other domains. This may reflect the types of content most salient on social media platforms. Parents are routinely exposed to curated portrayals of children's academic milestones, college admissions, honors, and socially valued experiences such as friendships, leadership roles, and popularity. Such content may render academic and social domains particularly salient and normatively loaded, fostering upward comparisons that recalibrate what parents perceive as "normal" or necessary for success. In contrast, expectations regarding household responsibilities or generalized life fulfillment may be less visible or less frequently showcased online.

These links are particularly notable given the abundant reasons parents have to *not* engage in social comparison with idealized depictions of high-achieving children online. After all, social comparison theory states that we compare ourselves against *relevant* others (Festinger, 1954). Seeing social media profiles of child prodigy musicians and 12-year-old medical students should be unlikely to influence most parents' expectations for their children, because those statistical outliers really shouldn't be perceived as appropriate or relevant objects of comparison. When you're in the gym, your expectations for how much you should be lifting might be raised when other people from your neighborhood are lifting significantly more than you. Your expectations for yourself are unlikely to go up when you watch a YouTube video of Bjorn Hafthor setting a world record by deadlifting 1,124 pounds. In addition, parents are motivated to make positive evaluations of their own children; in fact, there is a tendency for parents to judge specific domains of achievement as less important when they note that their own children do more poorly than other children (Thai et al., 2019).

Social media use was also positively associated with authoritarian parenting practices. Although the cross-sectional nature of the data precludes causal inference, several possible explanations for this relationship are worth considering. First, exposure may well drive authoritarian parenting practices. More exposure to idealized portrayals of high-achieving or well-behaved children may increase parental frustration or dissatisfaction, leading parents to adopt more controlling or punitive strategies in an effort to elicit desired outcomes. Certain parenting groups or influencers may advocate for more strict/authoritarian parenting practices, such as those sometimes characterized as “traditional parenting.” Alternatively, time spent on social media may reflect broader stress or overload, which has been linked in prior research to harsher parenting practices. Importantly, this association was independent of SCO, suggesting that social media use itself, not a tendency to engage in social comparison, is at issue.

Consistent with a substantial body of research documenting links between social media use and psychological distress, parents who reported spending more time on social media also reported higher levels of anxiety. Again, the direction of influence is unclear due to the cross-sectional nature of our data. This association may arise from greater exposure to alarming news, parenting-related fear appeals, or constant opportunities for upward comparison likely to arise in parents’ social media streams. For parents of adolescents and young adults, social media may also heighten concerns about children’s safety, social standing, or future prospects. On the other hand, parents may turn to social media in an attempt to distract themselves from negative feelings (including anxiety). It is also entirely possible that both processes are at work simultaneously, as social media elicit anxiety which parents then try to alleviate through more social media use. Similar reinforcing spirals have been documented in other types of problematic media content (Slater et al., 2007).

In addition to the limitations arising from the cross-sectional nature of our data, we need to keep at least one other limitation in mind, namely our recruitment method. Each participant was recruited by a student at a world-class public university in the United States. It seems likely that most participants were parents of those intelligent, competent, accomplished students. Negative effects of social comparison depend, in part, on what kind of comparison one is making. Reading descriptions of high-achieving teens on social media seems unlikely to make parents shift their expectations for their children if those children are already high-achieving teens. If anything, this would be expected to render our results more conservative than might be expected from a more diverse sample.

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